



99

FINE WINES
AND SPIRITS

5

LUXURY
CRUISES

TOTAL

1,478

**BUYERS
ARE NOW
INVESTING IN
EXPERIENCES,
IDENTITY,
AND LEGACY**

SOURCE BAIN & COMPANY
REPORT, 2024

insurgents like Nappa Dori, Mokobara, and incumbents like Titan have started to build into luggage and watches on the back of creating relevance, aspiration, and high-quality tech with an Indian design language,” he points out.

That said, the steady flow of more global brands into India continues—Valentino, Balenciaga, and Galeries Lafayette being some of them, apart from Elle Décor and Pottery Barn in the home décor space.

Specifically, for the three biggies in India, what has transpired in the luxury story in the last decade or so has opened a world of opportunities. Pushpa Bector, Senior ED, DLF Retail (the company owns DLF Emporio and The Chankaya in Delhi, both luxury shopping destinations), speaks of how the initial phase of luxury saw global brands take the franchise route. “Now, they are making a direct entry or through a JV (joint venture), meaning there is more

skin in the game,” she outlines. In the present day, shopping for luxury in India is more affordable compared to, say, Dubai, Singapore, or London, which used to be the mecca for big brands. The customer experience in India, she explains, is as good, if not better.

Easily, the clincher is the profile of the shopper. “A new India now has millennials who are aspirational from the word go. The luxury consumer is younger and feels very comfortable buying a pair of Golden Goose sneakers,” says Bector. Even the transition to branded jewellery was out of bounds for decades, but “the millennials want it.”

LUXURY IS NO longer merely about the ability to spend. K.T. Jithendran, MD & CEO, Birla Estates, talks of a shift in luxury real estate that is interesting because buyers are investing in experiences, identity, and legacy. “With rising wealth, global exposure, and heightened lifestyle aspirations, the Indian buyer is far more selective and thoughtful. It is no longer just about acquiring prime addresses or large homes but finding spaces that embody who they are and how they want to live,” he says. His company is primarily focused on premium and luxury residential housing, targeting high-net-worth individuals.

From a demographic point of view, the story is compelling. Bector says the India of today is confident with its citizens wanting and enjoying a good life. “The median age is 29, compared to 50 in Japan. For the youngsters, personal gratification is a big part of India’s story, and they are not awestruck by anything.”

Mathur explains that Indian brands are in the early stages of competing in the global markets. “All the relatively large brands have less than 20% of business coming from global markets and are currently not listed among the top 5 or 10 brands in any luxury category,” he says. The recipe for success revolves around consistent high-quality product delivery and marketing effort, along with wider work by the government. It is an arduous task, but one that is achievable to ensure Indian luxury makes it big on the global map. There is no reason why it cannot be done. **BT**

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